closely as possible. From the arm position and the release point I could assess what was coming at me and I tried to play as late as possible.

This exercise was draining and by the end of the day I was mentally exhausted. However, I had done what the team needed me to do: I had scored a hundred. I had forged an important partnership with Rahul, which was all the more satisfying because we had to negotiate a very hostile Jason Gillespie spell with the second new ball. Gillespie, who was tired after bowling all day, wasn't bowling quite so fast with the second new ball, but suddenly he gained inspiration from an unlikely source. One solitary Australian fan, sitting at the top of the sightscreen and carrying a huge toy kangaroo, started screaming after every delivery, urging Gillespie on. He was shouting 'Come on Aussie' each time he walked back to the end of his run-up. The fan had a huge impact on him. Within minutes Gillespie started to bowl really quickly again and was all fired up. Rahul and I even discussed what had happened to him all of a sudden. It just goes to show that you don't always need thousands of fans to motivate you.

Our partnership of 169 helped the team to an important 110-run lead, giving our bowlers some runs to play with in the second innings. The match was nicely poised in our favour and we knew we had a chance to close out the series. Hayden was once again going to be the crucial wicket. He fell for 35 to the bowling of Nilesh Kulkarni. Gilchrist was the other danger man lower down the order, because we knew he could score quickly and put the pressure back on us. But Bhajji, who had a grip on Gilchrist and Ponting right through the series, once again took the bulk of the Australian wickets, finishing off with a career-best haul of 8–84 in the innings. We needed 155 runs to win the series.

The chase started well and we were cruising before Mark Waugh pulled off an unbelievable catch at short midwicket. It was a full-blooded pull shot from VVS Laxman and Waugh just flung himself at full stretch to come up with a stunning catch. Laxman had been batting brilliantly for his 66 and his dismissal left us at 135–6, changing the course of the match yet again. Suddenly we had a contest on our hands.

By this stage, the whole team was sitting nervously outside the changing room. Everyone was told not to change seating positions and we were all feeling the tension. There were not too many runs left to get, but at stake was a series win against the world's best cricket team. The crowd was cheering every Indian run. It could not get any bigger.